

'end-to-end company' that provides everything including training, consulting, development and implementation. I would rather call ourselves assemblers of open source technologies. We are in the business of assembling the best of the open source tools and solutions available, building our own solutions as well and then providing the best possible alternatives to the customer."

Choosing the open source way was a deliberate move for Vineet and his team. He said, "Since the very beginning, we were sure of the fact that we did not want to do everything in the world, like most companies working in the IT space do. We wanted to be a niche player. We were not willing to go after the volume business; all we wanted to ensure was the quality of work that we delivered. We aimed at capturing the No 1 or No 2 spots in those particular streams of business. It was the time for PHP and MySQL. We started building enterprise grade solutions based on PHP and MySQL. Open source is a big world. Within that, we chose to hand pick niche technologies. We are not too good in domains like Linux and Java, but when it comes to technologies like MySQL, PHP, LAMP and Hadoop, I wouldn't be exaggerating if I say that we are the kings of this world."

Yes, there are other players in this space as well, but OSSCube thinks that the major differentiator for them is their ability to solve complex problems with their deep knowledge of the technologies.

The journey

Success never comes easily and is often accompanied by hardship. Vineet and his troop had their share of hindrances while making an open source business model a success. Vineet states, "Our biggest issue was getting the right kind of talent to work on the projects. It's no secret that India has a dearth of open source talent and almost all the companies working in this space face this crunch. The southern and the western parts of the country are comparatively better than North India. So, things were even worse for us." Being in the niche segment, there was no scarcity of business opportunities, but lack of talent to meet the market demand was an issue that OSSCube had to address on an urgent basis. The company initially went for the regular hiring process, but things did not work out well for them. Vineet explains, "We found that lateral hiring was not working out for us. We tried it for a couple of years and then we changed our strategy. We started hiring freshers from colleges. We started picking up students who had the basic knowledge. We then groomed them with the skillset required for our kind of jobs. This worked really well for us and we could manage to meet the clients' requirements."

OSSCube hires freshers from premium colleges across the country and trains them on open source technologies (primarily those technologies that the company uses). While on training, the candidates get a stipend, which is increased to a fully-fledged salary package soon after their training is finished. Vineet shares, "The training lasts for 6-8 months,

during which the candidates have to work on several practical assignments as well. After this rigorous training, the brighter lot is merged into our projects." This practice proved so fruitful for the company that the number of employees has currently increased to around 300. The company is now planning expansions in other parts of the country. Vineet said, "We will soon have our offices in Pune and Bengaluru."

The strategy

If you thought marketing is one of the key enablers for a business' success, think again and look at OSSCube. The company did not have any marketing or sales personnel till last year. Vineet takes pride in the fact that they could manage this far by word of mouth publicity. He says, "From the very beginning, we knew that we were not going on the usual path. So, we thought of doing things with a difference. The world of open source is incomplete without community involvement. We banked on this attribute of open source in a big way. We chose the community route to expand our business."

OSSCube has been actively involved in community initiatives, which have helped the company gain ground. He said, "India is a great open source consumer but a poor open source contributor. In order to increase the contribution, we encourage our employees to give away to the open source community. All this comes with perks, which they get on a monthly basis solely for contributing to the open source projects. This not only helps us give back to the community but also helps in building our brand image. We have built our firm only on the basis of word of mouth publicity, spread by the community members. We organised and participated in events related to open source, which is why we never felt the need to hire any sales personnel till last year. "When our work increased by leaps and bounds, it did not leave much scope for our employees to contribute. Unfortunately, our involvement and interactions with the community reduced as our business grew. So we had to hire a person who could handle the sales part. Having said that, we will get back to the way we originally worked from this financial year. We surely do not want to cut away from our roots."

The road ahead

OSSCube has been a success story. Vineet enthusiastically remarks, "Open source juggernaut has just started and the rate of innovation in this domain has been astounding! Cloud, Big data and enterprise mobility are trends that will fundamentally change how we use technology. It was hard to believe that you hardly pay anything for the software that powers almost everything in your life. Open source is set to take over the world," he chuckles. "The question is how can we stay at the forefront of it," he signs off! 

By: Diksha P Gupta

The author is assistant editor at EFY.